



DISCUSSION GUIDE

John Pavlovitz

Exit Interview: The Pastor I Wish I'd Been

John is a speaker, an author of several books and the blog “Stuff that Needs to be Said,” and a pastor to an online congregation. He identifies himself as a collector and curator of peoples’ stories, and he invites others to do the same.

REFLECT

1. John shares the conflict he experienced in ministry: wrestling with theological questions and doubt internally while expressing theological certainty to others. When have you felt a conflict between who you were becoming and what others expected of you?
2. Do you feel that church expands or shrinks your table (your community of people you listen to and care about)? If it shrinks it, how could the church begin to expand its table?

RESPOND

3. John urges us: “Get better stories!” Are there stories you fear hearing? What relationships could you begin or communities you could tap into to get a different perspective from your own?
4. “Authenticity and specificity” describe the approach John develops as he verbalizes both his questions and his convictions to his congregations and listeners. In what conversations does the church need to be a voice that:
 - acknowledges its own weakness or problems?
 - addresses injustice head-on?
 - allows people to vocalize doubt, fear, or uncertainty?